

Part I — The Census Bureau

One agency, three instruments, and the geography everything else is published on

84-355 Democracy's Data

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Almost every number you will meet in this book has a population underneath it. A turnout rate is votes divided by people. A claim that a district is majority Black is a count of people. A stop rate, a registration rate, a share of anything: all of them need somebody to have said how many people are there.

That bottom number, the thing you divide by, is called the **denominator**, and this book will come back to it constantly. Choosing the wrong one is the most common way a true number becomes a false sentence.

In the United States, that somebody is the **Census Bureau**, and this part is about what it does and how to read what it publishes.

The Bureau goes first for a plain reason. **16 of the 95 chapters in the rest of this book go to it for a number.** Not because those chapters are about the census. They are about traffic stops, turnout, district maps. They come here because their question needs a denominator, and this is where denominators come from.

01 One agency, three instruments, endlessly confused

The Bureau is not one survey. Its own catalogue lists 134 surveys and censuses. Three of them get almost all of this part, and it is worth saying now why those three and not the others.

It is because they are the three that get mistaken for each other. Each one answers some version of *how many people live here*. Each publishes a figure that looks like a population. Each carries the same agency's name and appears on the same website in the same typeface. Nobody has ever confused the Commodity Flow Survey with a headcount, because nothing about them looks alike. These three look exactly alike, and they are not the same:

- the **decennial census**, which tries to count everyone, once every ten years;
- the **American Community Survey**, which asks a sample of about 3.5 million addresses a year and publishes estimates with a margin of error — a stated range for how far off the estimate could be while still doing its job;
- the **population estimates**, which are a model that carries the last count forward using births, deaths and moves.

Ask the three of them for the population of one county and you will get three different numbers. None of them is wrong. They are answers to three different questions, and which one you quoted decides what your sentence means.

02 A survey that lives in the counting part

One thing here will look misfiled, and the explanation is worth having early.

The American Community Survey is a **survey** — it asks a sample of people questions, which is exactly what Part II is about. It is in this part anyway, because **answering it is required by law**. The same statute that compels the decennial count compels the ACS, and the envelope says so. Every survey in Part II is voluntary: you may hang up, and most people do.

That difference is not a technicality. It runs through everything the two kinds of data can be made to say, and holding the two side by side is one of the more useful things this book asks you to do.

03 The shape of this part

Every part of this book is built out of the same few moves, though no part uses all of them and the order changes when the material demands it. Here is what this one runs, and what each move is for:

Beat	Chapters	What it does
1 source	1	What this kind of data is, and what it structurally cannot say
2 instrument	4	One chapter per instrument that produces it
3 access	2	How you actually get hold of it, and what each route hands you
4 use	14	Chapters that use the data to answer a question

The rule is cumulative: **nothing in a later move is worked out from a source you have not already met**. If a chapter uses a file, the chapter that introduced that file came earlier.

Beat	Chapter	Title
1 source	census-source	What a Census Can and Cannot Do
2 instrument	census-decennial	The Decennial Census
2 instrument	census-acsc	The American Community Survey
2 instrument	census-pep	The Population Estimates Program
2 instrument	census-geography	Census Geography and Why Data Will Not Join
3 access	census-access	How Many People Live in Allegheny County?
3 access	census-api	Using the Census Data API
4 use	census-race	Hispanic Origin Is Not a Race on the Census Form
4 use	census-coverage	Who the Count Missed
4 use	demographics	Measuring Race at Eight Geographic Scales
4 use	areal-units	The Modifiable Areal Unit Problem
4 use · companion	overplotting	When a Scatter Plot Has Too Many Points
4 use	zip-codes	What a ZIP Code Is, and What It Is Not

Beat	Chapter	Title
4 use	apportionment	Apportionment: How a Count Becomes Seats
4 use	regional-shift	Regional Population Shift and House Seats
4 use	migration	Measuring Migration with ACS Flow Estimates
4 use · companion	chord	Everybody Moved, Almost Nobody Left
4 use	age-structure	The Age Structure of the Electorate
4 use	section-203	Section 203 Language Coverage Determinations
4 use	names	Names as Data
4 use	surnames	Surname-Based Race Inference

Read the length of the fourth row. 14 of the 21 chapters here are chapters that *use* the data rather than introduce it. A part is mostly its applications; the opening chapters exist so that the applications can be read.

04 You will meet this data again

Quantity	Chapters
Chapters outside this part	95
Of those, that go to the Census Bureau themselves	16
Of those, that read this part's own derived files	3

Two numbers, and the gap between them is the honest shape of this part's importance.

16 chapters elsewhere in this book go to the Census Bureau themselves. They come for a turnout denominator, a benchmark for traffic stops, or a check on a guess about somebody's race. Or for a population to compare a survey against.

But only **3** of them read *this part's* files. It would be easy, and wrong, to claim that everything else rests on Part I. It does not.

The true version is narrower and more useful. **This is the source the rest of the book keeps going back to, independently, on its own terms.** That is exactly why it is worth a part of its own. You meet it here, rather than first meeting it as somebody else's denominator.

05 How to read this part

Start with what a census is, then take the three instruments in order. They are ordered by how often they are mistaken for each other, not by importance.

If you only have time for two chapters, read the source chapter and the one on the instrument you are actually about to use. If you already know which file you need, the access chapter is the fastest route. Read its finding first, because the Bureau has more than a dozen published answers in print for one county's population, and naming which one you mean is the whole skill.

06 Sources

- The corpus itself. The chapter list, its order and each chapter's subject are read from this book's own INDEX.md, so this page cannot disagree with the part it opens; reorganise the part and rebuild, and the tables above follow.
- U.S. Constitution, Article I, Section 2; the Census Act, 13 U.S.C., including § 221, which makes answering compulsory; Public Law 94-171(1975); and Section 203 of the Voting Rights Act. Between them these four obligations produce almost everything in this part.